AI FOR MANAGERS

The Study Guide Collection

All twenty-one lesson guides in one place – the core idea, the frameworks, and what to do differently after every lesson of the course. Keep it beside the videos, and beside your 60-Day AI Adoption Workbook.

MOVE 1

Assess

Build a real picture of how AI is already used in your team.

MOVE 2

Align

Turn the picture into one shared Team Working Standard.

MOVE 3

Control

Put the checks where the risk enters the work.

MOVE 4

Lead

Turn the standard into durable capability.

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What Are You Going to Learn?

What will I learn, what will I build, and how does this course work?

MODULE 1 · LESSON 0 | WHAT JUST CHANGED | Course introduction · ~5 min

THE CORE IDEA

AI adoption isn't won or lost in the boardroom – it's won or lost on your team, and leading it is a management challenge with a method.

You don't need to be an AI expert. You need a framework that turns individual experiments into a deliberate way of working – and this course hands you one.

1 The situation this course is built for

AI is past the point of hype: it's built into the tools your team already uses, and by now it's almost certainly part of how the work gets done. This course is built for exactly that situation – managers whose teams use AI in everyday knowledge work: writing, analysis, research, client work. Not AI coding, and not prompting tutorials – the work your team already does.

2 Where AI adoption gets decided

Look at where you sit. Above you, leadership has made AI a priority and wants it to pay off. Below you, your people are already experimenting – some quietly ahead, some unsure what they're even allowed to use. Neither force becomes anything on its own: **a strategy from the top is just a slide deck until a team actually works differently, and energy from the bottom is loose effort until someone gives it shape.** That someone is you.

Your question isn't which app or which prompt – that's for the people doing the work. Yours sits one level up: how do you turn all those individual experiments into a deliberate way of working – your team adopting AI and integrating it into the real work, without losing control of quality or your people?

3 A management problem – and those have methods

This isn't really a technology problem; it's a management one. And management challenges have methods. That's the promise of the course: a clear, practical way to lead this, step by step – so AI in your team stops being something that happens *to* you and becomes something you *lead*.

4 The method: one framework, four moves

The method is one framework – the **Team AI Integration Framework** – and it works in four moves.

Assess

Build a clear picture of how AI is actually being used across your team: the tools, the tasks, where it helps, where the risk sits. From here on – no guesswork.

Align

Agree a short, explicit shared standard for whenever the team uses AI. People keep their own judgment, but the matters that affect everyone get one shared answer.

Control

Place simple checks at the exact moments that matter: where data goes in, where AI-made work becomes the basis for a decision, and where it goes out to a client.

Lead

Keep adoption alive and growing, person by person – so capability compounds over time instead of quietly fading.

The four moves then come together in the **60-Day Plan** – the course's capstone deliverable: a sequenced implementation plan that puts everything you've learned into motion, built using the 60-Day AI Adoption Workbook. So you leave not with ideas, but with motion.

5 What you'll build, and how the course works

You don't just learn this – you build it. By the end you'll have five working outputs: your **Team AI Baseline**, a **Team Working Standard**, a **Checkpoint Map**, a **Lead AI Adoption Plan**, and your own **60-Day Plan** – real documents for your team's actual work, not course notes. A completed example shows you what good looks like. You build them with your team, or you leave ready to build them.

The way there fits the job you already have: practical lessons, built on real situations, and what to do in them. No prompting tutorials, no tool comparisons – and no need to do it all at once. You go at your team's pace.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Treat AI adoption as decided at **team level** – your level – not in the boardroom.
- Frame the work ahead as management, not technology – you don't need to become the AI expert to lead it.
- Keep the four moves – **Assess, Align, Control, Lead** – as your map for the whole course.
- Expect to build as you go: five working outputs for your real team, at your team's pace.
- Start where every good decision starts – with seeing clearly what's already happening.

Module 1 · What Just Changed – this module builds the case for why managing AI use is now part of your role. Your companion for the whole course is the 60-Day AI Adoption Workbook, which collects every exercise into your capstone 60-Day Plan. **Next: Lesson 1.1 – AI Is Already in Your Team** – the first thing to see clearly: AI is already shaping real work in your team, whether you've mapped it or not.

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AI Is Already in Your Team

How much AI use is already happening in my team?

MODULE 1 · LESSON 1 | WHAT JUST CHANGED | Awareness lesson · 4–6 min

THE CORE IDEA

AI entered teams before managers created structures to manage it.

AI use is almost certainly already part of how your team works — and your visibility into it is lower than you assume.

1 Your picture is probably incomplete

Ask yourself: do you have a real view of where AI is already shaping the work your team produces? Not whether people are interested in it, or have tried it — where it is actually shaping finished work. Most managers don't have that visibility yet. Not because they failed to pay attention: visibility is structurally hard to get, for two reasons.

2 The two reasons you can't see it

People rarely surface their own AI use

People use AI for drafting, summarizing, research, and writing help — through tools they find themselves. They don't announce it, and there has never been an expectation that they should. Your awareness tracks only the visible surface; the actual practice is broader.

The finished work doesn't show it

A report written with AI assistance looks like a report. A client email drafted with AI looks like a client email. AI does not announce itself in the end result — and this goes beyond unofficial tools. Approved tools, and the AI built into software the team already works in, leave no marker either. **It just looks like work.**

Put the two together — nobody surfaces it, and the work doesn't show it — and the picture will not correct itself on its own.

3 The scale of what's invisible

Microsoft and LinkedIn's 2024 Work Trend Index surveyed 31,000 knowledge workers across 31 countries. Three findings, each telling you something different:

75%
were using AI at work

78%
of those users were bringing their **own** AI tools to work

52%
were reluctant to admit using AI for their most important tasks

Microsoft & LinkedIn, Work Trend Index 2024.

These figures don't tell you what is happening in *your* team. They show why relying only on visible or formally announced use leaves a manager with an incomplete picture.

4 This has a name: Shadow AI

> **TERM – SHADOW AI**
> People using AI tools at work outside the formal systems, policies, or expectations of the organization.

It matters because it is the part of your team's AI use you cannot see – already shaping real work without appearing in any tool list, policy discussion, or team meeting. But in most teams, Shadow AI is not a story of bad intent. It is what happens when a useful technology arrives before the structures to manage it. People use what works. Some keep quiet out of worry it will reflect badly on them – but for most, it simply never occurred to them that their AI use was worth mentioning.

5 Asking directly changes the picture

Because the picture won't correct itself, direct questions often reveal a different reality from the one you thought you were seeing – how widespread the use is, how much real work it already shapes, and why you have never heard about it.

THREE QUESTIONS THAT SURFACE IT

1. Who has used AI at work in the last two weeks?
2. Who has used it for something significant – something that actually shaped a piece of work?
3. And who told me about it when it happened?

Caution: asking these openly only works where honest answers are already safe. Without that safety, start smaller – ask privately or in writing, and let people respond on their own terms. Module 2 builds the full method for getting this picture.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Treat your current picture of AI use as **partial by default** – visible and announced use is the surface, not the whole.
- Stop expecting the finished work to reveal AI involvement – it won't, even from approved tools.
- Read Shadow AI as a **structure gap, not misconduct** – the predictable result of tools arriving before structures.
- Shift the question from *"is AI use happening?"* to *"can I see enough of it to understand what has changed?"*

Module 1 · What Just Changed – this module builds the case for why managing AI use is now part of your role. **Next: Lesson 1.2 – The Mandate Without a Method** – why you're expected to lead this change without ever being handed a method for it.

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The Mandate Without a Method

Why don't I know what to do with this?

MODULE 1 · LESSON 2 | WHAT JUST CHANGED | Awareness lesson · 5–7 min

THE CORE IDEA

Managers became accountable for AI before receiving a management model – and the absence of that model does not remove the need to act.

The problem is not that the change escaped you. The problem is that responsibility arrived before any method for handling it.

1 Pressure from two directions

You are probably feeling this change from one of two directions – and each tells you something different.

From below

People are already using AI tools individually, quietly, without it coming up in team discussions. You can sense that something has shifted in how the work gets made – but you don't yet have a clear way to lead that shift.

From above

A town hall, an all-hands, an email from leadership: AI is a strategic priority, and managers are expected to help make it happen. But the expectation arrived without much instruction.

Either way, the situation is the same: something significant is shifting in how your team works, and you are now expected to respond.

2 The need to act is already there

Whether or not your organization has declared AI a priority, the need to act has probably already arrived from below. The quiet activity the previous lesson made visible – **Shadow AI** – is already creating a management need, whether or not anyone has named it. Tools may be in use without shared rules. Information may be entering systems through workflows you have not yet seen. That creates **credible exposure** – a real risk to data or quality. Not proof that something has gone wrong, but enough reason to establish what is happening rather than wait for an announcement from the top.

3 A clear goal with no operational path

The expectation from above – spoken or unspoken – turns that need into a goal: make AI work well, for your team, in your context. The goal sounds clear enough. But it leaves the operational questions undefined: which tools, for which tasks, with what standards. How to handle team members who resist or struggle. What good AI use looks like versus use that only looks real on paper. What the risks are, and who is accountable.

TERM – COMPLIANCE THEATRE

Activity that looks like adoption but does not prove real capability or useful change – training completions, tool logins, or claims of AI use that don't show whether the work is actually improving.

You are told where to end up – not how to get there. That gap is why many managers hesitate: setting standards in a domain where you don't yet feel fully confident is hard, so acting can feel exposed and waiting safer. That's understandable. But the difficulty doesn't remove the need – it shows why a method matters.

4 Organizational guidance sets boundaries – the team level is yours

Even where your organization has issued guidance – acceptable-use policies, approved tool lists, training – it mostly sets boundaries: which tools are approved, what data rules apply, when to bring in legal or security. Use those where you have them, and push for answers where you don't. But none of it tells you how AI should fit your team's actual work – and that part is still yours to manage. That team-level work is what the rest of the course gives you a method for: a clearer picture of current AI use, then shared standards, workflow checks, and a real way to drive adoption.

5 A management challenge, not a technology challenge

You do need enough AI understanding to lead responsibly – what the tools can do, where they tend to fail, and why a convincing output is not always a correct one. But you don't need to become the technical expert on every tool your team might use. Your role is to create the conditions in which AI can be used well: enough **visibility** to see what is happening, enough **shared practice** to avoid everyone inventing their own rules, enough **control** to catch problems before they matter, and enough **insight into your people** to know whether adoption is real.

That is management work. **The tools are new. The responsibility is not.** Waiting until you feel sufficiently expert means waiting for a threshold that keeps moving. You are not behind because you missed something – you are in the position most managers are in right now. What is missing is not capability. It is a method – and a method can be built.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Accept that AI management has become **part of your role** – responsible for something real that already requires a response.
- Stop treating "wait for perfect guidance" as neutral – existing AI activity means waiting is a choice with consequences.
- Use organizational policy for boundaries, push for answers where it's silent – and own how AI fits your team's actual work.
- Read adoption signals skeptically: logins and training completions can be **compliance theatre**, not capability.
- Reframe the gap as a **missing method, not missing capability** – and a method can be built.

Module 1 · What Just Changed – this module builds the case for why managing AI use is now part of your role. **Next: Lesson 1.3 – AI Is Changing Work, Task by Task** – before the method begins, see the change clearly: how AI is changing the work itself, task by task.

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AI Is Changing Work, Task by Task

What exactly has changed in how my team works?

MODULE 1 · LESSON 3 | WHAT JUST CHANGED | Awareness lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

The most useful place to understand AI's effect on work is not the whole role – it's the task, and the process inside it.

The output still looks the same. The work behind it doesn't – and you're accountable for the part you can no longer see.

1 Was your model built before AI – or after?

Think about one task your team does regularly – a first draft, a research summary, a weekly status update, a client email. You have a mental model of how it gets made: the steps, the time it takes, the skills it calls for, what a good version looks like. You built that model over time, from observation and experience. The question is: was it built before AI, or after? If before – and for most managers it was – something important may have shifted underneath it: gradually, invisibly, and without anyone telling you. The shift has three parts: it happens at the **task level**, it happens **in the process**, and it lands **unevenly**.

2 Task level – inside the job, not the whole role

Whole-role questions – will this job still exist? – are already real in some fields. But for most managers, the more immediate and useful place to look is inside the role, at the tasks that make up the work. AI rarely shows up as a whole new job; it reaches into specific pieces – drafting a section, summarising a document, pulling together research – and changes how that piece gets done. Picture any role as a bundle of tasks: a team lead drafts updates, prepares analysis, runs one-to-ones, reviews others' work. AI might reshape the drafting and the analysis while leaving the one-to-ones and the judgment inside those reviews largely untouched. The job title stays the same while, one task at a time, the work changes.

3 In the process – where you can't see it

Any piece of work runs on the same simple shape: **Input** (what goes in) → **Process** (the steps that turn it into a result) → **Output** (what comes out). AI changes the process – often significantly, often in ways that never surface in the output. The slow part of a task can collapse to a fraction of what it took, while the judgment that matters – what to include, what the reader actually needs, which risk to flag – stays exactly where it was, or matters more than before.

Newer tools push even more of the work into that invisible middle. A simple AI chat helps with one visible step; an **agentic tool** takes a broader goal and moves through several steps – research, selection, drafting, checking – before the result appears. The more of the process AI handles, the less the finished output tells you about how the work was made. This is how the gap between the manager's picture and the team's reality opens – without anyone announcing it.

4 Uneven – it hits people differently

Inside "my team uses AI," the variation is significant – and it is not random. Sorting people into users and non-users explains very little. Two dimensions matter most, because managers usually see one and miss the other. The first is **willingness** – the enthusiastic adopter, the reluctant one, the person who tried it once and went back. It matters, but it doesn't explain the whole pattern. The second is **task fit**, the one that gets missed: AI is strong on structured writing, summarising, first drafts, and processing information – weak on nuanced judgment, relationship work, and decisions that need deep context.

> **TERM – JAGGED FRONTIER**
>
> The boundary between where AI helps and where it doesn't is uneven and hard to predict – and it doesn't track job title, seniority, or willingness.

That's why two people with the same job title can have completely different experiences: the actual mix of tasks they spend their days on usually differs, and the frontier runs through each mix differently. Task fit sits alongside other conditions – access, time, confidence, trust, whether it's expected of them. Treat all of it as willingness, and you'll misread what's happening.

TRY IT – PRESSURE-TEST ONE MENTAL MODEL

1. Pick one task your team does regularly – a first draft, a research summary, a status update.
2. Walk through how you believe it gets made: the steps, the time, the skills, what good looks like.
3. Ask yourself when you built that picture – before AI, or after? Then ask the person who does the task how it's made today.

Why the last step matters: the change doesn't show in the output, so asking is the only way to see it – and most managers haven't asked yet.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Stop reasoning about AI at the level of **whole roles** – look inside the job, task by task.
- Expect the change **in the process, not the output** – finished work will keep looking normal.
- Read variation across your team as **task fit and conditions**, not just willingness – the users/non-users binary explains little.
- Treat your mental model of how the work gets made as **dated until checked** – and check by asking, not by inspecting outputs.

Module 1 · What Just Changed – this module builds the case for why managing AI use is now part of your role. **Next: Lesson 1.4 – Why This Matters for You as a Manager** – what the change means for you, and the structured response the rest of the course is built on.

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Why This Matters for You as a Manager

So what do I actually do about all of this?

MODULE 1 · LESSON 4 | WHAT JUST CHANGED | Decision / bridge lesson · 5–7 min

THE CORE IDEA

The answer to AI uncertainty is management infrastructure — not more AI knowledge.

Assess, Align, Control, Lead: four moves that rebuild your picture and let you manage both the opportunity and the risk.

1 The opportunity and the risk

An incomplete picture of your team's AI use carries two things at once. The **opportunity** is real: first drafts that used to take half a day taking an hour; research tasks that needed a team starting with one person and AI. The gains are not uniform — they depend on task type and on how well each person has learned to use the tools — but where they land, they are real. The **risk** is just as real, and less visible: the same change may be altering how the work gets made in ways that don't show up in the deliverables, with new practices forming informally — the Shadow AI from lesson one — without shared rules. You are responsible for the work, the people producing it, and the capability they are building — or not building. That responsibility didn't change because the tools changed. What changed is what you need to *see* in order to live up to it.

2 Two management problems — one owner

The opportunity going unmanaged. What one person figures out stays with that person unless someone turns it into team practice. Sometimes it spreads on its own; mostly it doesn't, or slowly and unevenly. Someone needs to ensure a shared standard exists and holds. That someone is you.

The risk going unseen. Client data pasted into a tool nobody checked. A confident-sounding figure nobody verified. You don't yet know whether these things are happening in your team — and that is exactly the point. Someone needs to establish what is happening and put the right checks in the right places. That someone is also you.

3 The deeper cost: reproducibility

Step back from any single incident and you reach the deeper cost. What makes your team valuable isn't any one deliverable — it's the ability to produce a result **reliably**: to a known standard, again and again, in a way you can plan around and stand behind. That reliability rests on you understanding how the work gets made. When the process changes while your picture does not, you cannot tell what the work has come to depend on: a report that looks solid today might be resting on one person's private workaround, or on a tool that quietly stops being reliable tomorrow. The real cost is not a single bad output — it is **losing your confidence that good output can be reproduced on purpose**. And without visibility into how the work actually gets made, feedback, evaluation, coaching, and risk management are all operating on assumptions.

4 The response: the Team AI Integration Framework

That is the shape of the problem: AI already in your team beyond what is visible, the work changing task by task, gains staying individual, risks still unidentified — and you accountable for a clearer picture, without a

method for it. The response is the **Team AI Integration Framework** you met in the course introduction. Now you know why it has that shape: four moves, in sequence, each addressing a specific part of what this module established, each creating the conditions the next requires.

Assess
Gives you the baseline: who uses AI, for which tasks, at what level, with what risks already present. Everything that follows is built on that.

Align
Turns what you find into a shared standard – agreed practices for how AI integrates into your team's specific workflows, so variation becomes consistency.

Control
Puts specific verification checkpoints inside specific workflows, so problems are caught before they reach decisions or clients.

Lead
Reinforces adoption, develops capability, and turns individual learning into shared team practice – so the standard is actually used and improved.

You don't need to become an AI expert to do any of this. You need enough understanding to know what the tools do, where they fail, and what good output looks like – and the management structure to act on it. These are management moves. You are not behind because you missed something. You are in the position most managers are in right now – with one difference: now you have the method.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Name both sides for your own team: where the **gains** are landing, and where unreviewed practice may be forming.
- Treat **visibility as the prerequisite** – without it, feedback, evaluation, coaching, and risk management run on assumptions.
- Judge your team's position by **reproducibility**, not single outputs: can good work be repeated on purpose?
- Commit to the sequence – **Assess, Align, Control, Lead** – starting with Assess, not with more AI knowledge.

Module 1 · What Just Changed – this module built the case for why managing AI use is now part of your role. **Next: Module 2, Lesson 2.1 – Your Performance Picture Is Broken** – the Assess move begins, with a shift of focus from the work to the people doing it.

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Your Performance Picture Is Broken

Can I still trust the signals I use to evaluate my team?

MODULE 2 · LESSON 1 | THE NEW PERFORMANCE PROBLEM | Decision lesson · 7–9 min

THE CORE IDEA

When AI changes how work gets produced, traditional performance signals become weaker.

Speed, comparison, and the deliverable itself all read the same surface — the output — and that surface no longer reflects how the work was made.

1 This module begins the Assess move

Module 1 showed AI changing the work itself — inside the process, invisibly in the output, unevenly across your people. This module is the response: the first of the **Team AI Integration Framework**'s four moves — **Assess**, before Align, Control, and Lead. Assess gives you the baseline: before you can set standards, design controls, or develop people, you need an accurate picture of what is actually happening. Across three lessons, this module builds that picture — captured as your **Team AI Baseline**.

2 Three signals, one broken assumption

Speed. Comparison. The deliverable itself. These are the signals you rely on to read how your team is doing. Where people have integrated AI into their work, all three have become unreliable — not because you stopped paying attention, but because all three read the same surface: the output. AI changed how work gets made inside the process while the deliverable kept looking normal, or better than normal. The assumption that the surface still reflects the work is what broke.

3 Speed has become a question

Speed was always an imperfect signal for mastery, but a useful one. AI made it much harder to trust: a first draft in twenty minutes that used to take three hours is evidence of a tool, not of improved skill. And the tool helps most when the task is straightforward, and least — or actively misleads — when the task requires judgment, nuance, or deep context. Studies on well-matched tasks have found speed improvements of 25–40%; on tasks outside AI's range — complex, ambiguous, context-heavy — some of the same research finds users with AI perform *worse* than those without it, despite delivering faster. **Speed is no longer a reliable signal. It has become a question.**

4 You may be comparing conditions

When you compare two people's output, you assume you are comparing their capability. AI has made that unreliable, because it has not changed everyone's work process equally. One person's structured, text-heavy tasks sit exactly where AI changes the process most; another's work runs on ambiguity and judgment, where AI helps least. Compare them at review time and you are comparing outputs from very different processes — a difference invisible in what arrives on your desk. That is the **jagged frontier** — the uneven, hard-to-predict boundary of where AI helps — showing up in your performance data. And task fit is not the only condition: access, confidence, peer coaching, informal training, and clarity about approved tools also shape what each

person can do with AI. Performance management calls the resulting mistake **attribution error**: seeing an output gap and assuming a capability gap, when it may be a conditions gap. **You may not be comparing people. You may be comparing conditions.**

5 The deliverable no longer shows who did the thinking

A strong piece of work used to mean something specific: the person who submitted it mostly created it. Today the same finished document might mean the person thought deeply and wrote every word; or wrote a prompt, reviewed the output quickly, and sent it on; or something in between – and it looks identical in all three cases. Studies on professional writing tasks found that lower-ability workers benefited more from AI than higher-ability workers, shrinking gaps in quality and speed. A less experienced team member can now produce output that looks like senior work – sometimes genuinely valuable, sometimes masking a capability gap that only surfaces when judgment, context, or accountability is actually required. The deliverable still matters, but it is no longer enough. You also need to know what role the person played in producing it.

THE PERFORMANCE QUESTIONS

1. Did they define the problem?
2. Did they decide what mattered?
3. Did they exercise judgment about what to include and what to cut?
4. Did they verify the parts that needed verification?
5. Could they explain the reasoning without the finished document doing the work for them?

These are performance questions now – they tell you whether someone is building capability or producing stronger-looking output with support from a tool.

Three signals, all disrupted by the same shift, at the same time. If only one had broken, you could lean on the others. When the deliverable stops telling you who did the thinking, you have run out of signals – which is why a better baseline comes before performance conclusions.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Stop reading faster delivery as improved capability – treat speed as a **question** about how the work was produced.
- Before ranking people against each other, check whether you are comparing capability or **conditions** – task fit, access, training, tool clarity.
- Stop treating a strong deliverable as proof of who did the thinking – ask what role the person played in producing it.
- Hold performance conclusions until you have a real baseline of how the work is actually being made – building one is what this module gives you.

Module 2 · The New Performance Problem – this module runs the Assess move: building the baseline you need before drawing conclusions. **Next: Lesson 2.2 – The Output Looks Fine – That's the Problem** – how AI can hand your team work that looks sound while hiding errors your review was never built to catch.

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The Output Looks Fine — That's the Problem

If the work looks good, what's the problem?

MODULE 2 · LESSON 2 | THE NEW PERFORMANCE PROBLEM | Decision lesson · 6–8 min

THE CORE IDEA

AI errors are dangerous because they often look correct.

Credible-looking output can carry hidden risk — and without a shared way to check AI-assisted work, there is nothing to point to when something goes wrong.

1 Something goes wrong — and you can't trace it

A piece of work goes out from your team — well-structured, clearly written, no obvious problems. Then a client flags a figure that doesn't match their data, or a decision gets made on information that turns out to be incorrect. You go back to understand what happened — and realize you have no idea. You don't know which parts were AI-generated, what was reviewed, whether the sources were checked. There is no trail and no agreed process to point to. Errors slipping past review is a familiar problem; this is its new version. The work looked fine. That was the problem. Underneath sit two problems that together turn a single slip into an ongoing risk.

Problem 1 — the invisible error

AI mistakes that don't look like mistakes.

Problem 2 — the missing net

No shared way to catch them before the work goes out.

2 The invisible error

When humans make mistakes in knowledge work, there are usually surface signals — something is missing, the logic trails off, a number doesn't add up. Your review habits were built to notice those traces. AI introduces a different pattern: work that is structured, fluent, and confident even when something inside it is wrong. The error enters *inside the process*, before your review ever sees the finished work — so the surface arrives polished while a source, figure, assumption, or recommendation underneath it is wrong. A fabricated statistic reads exactly like a real one. A misrepresented source sounds authoritative.

TERM — HALLUCINATION

AI producing output that is factually wrong but presented as if it were correct. The management implication: you cannot use how confident or polished the work sounds to judge whether it is right.

In one study of management consultants, those who used AI on a task built to fall outside its range were about **19 percentage points less likely** than colleagues without AI to reach the right answer — and they finished faster. In practice: an attorney in the US submitted a legal brief citing cases that did not exist, all generated by AI. The citations were plausible and professionally formatted; nothing in the brief signalled that checking them against a legal database was necessary. **The errors AI introduces are often not the ones managers are trained to catch.**

3 The missing net

Even when an error like that slips through, most teams have no net to catch it. AI is being used without a shared understanding of what that means for quality, review, or accountability: hardly anyone has agreed what "reviewed" means when AI contributed, what gets disclosed, or what the standard is for client-facing work. Accountability needs a process – it is not enough for each person to decide privately what counts as checked. **Shadow AI** – the quiet, unannounced use – widens the gap: most people are not hiding anything; no one ever agreed what should be mentioned. The result is a team producing AI-assisted work at volume with no shared way to check it.

When something goes wrong, you can't blame the tool. **Accountability follows whoever sent the work.** The gap is the team's problem – but the person who hit "send" is left holding the consequences. And the gap persists even in compliance-heavy organizations: a policy, an approved tool list, a completed training tell you nothing about whether *this* piece of work was checked the right way. The real question isn't "did we follow the policy?" It's "do we actually know what got checked before this went out?"

4 Where your exposure sits right now

Put the two problems together – errors that don't look like errors, and no net to catch them – and a single slip becomes an ongoing risk. Three questions show where you currently stand – not to solve anything yet, but to see clearly.

THREE QUESTIONS ON YOUR EXPOSURE

1. Do I know which of my team's recent outputs involved AI?
2. If something went wrong in recent work, could I trace what happened and why?
3. Have my team and I ever agreed on what "reviewed" means when AI is part of the process?

If the answer to all three is no, the gap is real and it is open right now. The next lesson builds the picture that lets you answer them.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Stop using polish and confidence as a proxy for correctness – the dangerous errors **read as correct**.
- Assume your review habits were built for human error patterns; AI's errors enter earlier, inside the process.
- Treat "no incident yet" as no evidence – the gap stays invisible until something goes wrong.
- Remember accountability follows whoever **sent** the work, not the tool – a shared checking standard protects your people, not just quality.
- Sit with the three exposure questions honestly – they define the gap this module starts closing.

Module 2 · The New Performance Problem – this module runs the Assess move: replacing assumptions with a baseline of what is actually happening. **Next: Lesson 2.3 – How to Assess Your Team's AI Use** – the method that turns the missing picture into your Team AI Baseline.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

How to Assess Your Team's AI Use

How do I get a clear picture of what's actually happening in my team?

MODULE 2 · LESSON 3 | THE NEW PERFORMANCE PROBLEM | Action lesson · 10–13 min

THE CORE IDEA

You cannot manage what you have not made visible.

The AI Baseline Assessment replaces assumptions with evidence – a written picture of your team's actual AI use, captured as your Team AI Baseline.

1 From open questions to a real picture

The last two lessons left three questions open: which outputs involved AI, whether you could trace what happened, and what "reviewed" means when AI is in the process. For most managers the honest answer to at least one is no – and none of it can be fixed until you can see what your team is doing. This lesson is the how: a structured set of questions, in the right sequence, that make visible what AI has made invisible. The written record is the **Team AI Baseline** – the output of Assess, which the rest of the framework builds on.

2 The four areas of the AI Baseline Assessment

Each area makes the process layer visible – the part AI has changed in ways the finished work doesn't show.

Usage – what is actually happening

Which tools each person uses, for which tasks, how often – and which tasks they avoid AI for, and why. The factual foundation.

Impact – what has changed

What's faster, where quality has shifted, what time goes to now, what has dropped away. Watch for separate steps collapsing into one AI-assisted step – the informal checks inside them collapse too.

Capability – what AI use means for development

Which skills are used more, which less; if AI vanished for a week, what would feel hardest; can they walk through the reasoning without the document. This answers the attribution question – the line between person, tool, and what may be weakening.

Risk – where the exposure is

What information they're unsure about putting into tools, what they do before using or sending AI output, whether a consistent checking process exists.

3 Two things before you start

Start with yourself. Run the assessment on your own work first – which tools, which tasks, what has changed, where your own risks are. You are doing what you ask of them – and it surfaces your own blind spots first.

Frame it for your team. Without context, asking about AI use can feel like surveillance; with framing, it becomes an invitation. Before conversations start, tell the team what you are doing and why, what you will do with the information, and what it is *not* – not an audit, not about catching people out, not about restricting

how they work. Framing gets honest answers; skipping it gets guarded ones, and a picture that doesn't reflect reality.

4 The default gathering path

Written check-in → one-to-one follow-up → team-level pattern discussion → optional working alongside. Start in writing: low friction, time to think – and where trust is still forming, asking in writing beats asking in front of the room. Follow up in one-to-ones where you need depth, especially on capability and risk. Use the group session for patterns only, never individual profiles; voluntary show-and-tell works once trust is established. Working alongside someone gives the most accurate picture but stays optional.

5 What it produces: the Team AI Baseline

For each person, summarize what you found across the four areas – **Usage, Impact, Capability, Risk** – plus brief notes, on a simple three-point scale: ●○○ limited, ●●○ developing, ●●● strong. This is **not a performance rating** – it is your current snapshot, and the blanks you can't fill are findings in themselves. Then fill in a team row: the lowest-scoring areas are where you are most exposed right now. The team row can be shared – it shows the overall picture without exposing anyone's profile, and makes the need for a shared standard tangible from within the team. Written down, the baseline is something you can return to and update; writing up the summaries is itself a good low-stakes AI task, within your organization's data rules.

6 Optional add-on: the AI Opportunity Scan

If your baseline comes back nearly empty, first check whether low use is real or just unsurfaced – invisible use is more common than absence. If it is genuinely low, ask each person three light questions: which tasks are repetitive, where gathering information takes significant time before the actual thinking, and what feels slow or effortful out of proportion to the output. Filter the raw list with one impact question – *if we improved this, would it materially help the team or the work?* – and keep only the shortlist. Don't choose tools yet. The baseline captures current reality; the scan previews potential – a direction instead of a blank page. Teams further along do opportunity-finding later, in the Lead move.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Run the **AI Baseline Assessment** with your team this week – written check-in first, then depth where needed.
- Run it on yourself before anyone else – you're joining, not auditing.
- Send the framing message before any conversations start: what you're doing, why, and what it is not.
- Write the results down as your **Team AI Baseline** – per person and a team row across Usage, Impact, Capability, and Risk.
- Share the team row with the team – it makes the case for a shared standard better than an announcement can.

Module 2 · The New Performance Problem – this module runs the Assess move; it is done when your Team AI Baseline exists. Download with this lesson: Handout B – Assess Question Prompts (the full set of question prompts). **Next: Module 3, Lesson 3.1 – You Have a Picture, You Don't Have a Standard** – the Align move begins: what you do with the picture.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

You Have a Picture. You Don't Have a Standard.

The baseline shows how differently people work with AI. What does the team now need to agree on, together?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 1 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Module opener · 3–4 min

THE CORE IDEA

A picture of AI use is not a standard for it.

Align turns individual variation into one shared agreement – and that agreement has to be set, not left to chance.

1 From seeing to agreeing

Assess gave you something you did not have before: a clear picture of how AI is already shaping your team's work – your **Team AI Baseline**. That picture keeps paying off through the rest of the course. But some of what it surfaces needs a team-level answer now. That is where **Align** – the second move of the framework – begins. Align turns the picture into a shared standard, and your job changes with it: from seeing what is happening to agreeing how your team will work.

2 A picture isn't a standard

Look again at what the baseline shows. People use different tools, review AI-assisted work differently, and make different assumptions about what information is acceptable to put in. Seeing those differences is not the same as settling them.

Not every difference should disappear – people do different work and should keep their **professional judgment**. But the matters that affect everyone need one shared answer: which tools and data are acceptable, what has to be reviewed, and when AI use should be visible. Picture one recurring task – the same weekly update – produced three different ways by three people, one of them through a personal AI account. The variation is visible; a shared answer to any of it is not.

So what the baseline reveals is not a set of individual problems to fix one conversation at a time. It is **one missing team standard** – and it has to be agreed once, together.

3 What Align builds

TERM – TEAM WORKING STANDARD

The output of Align: a shared agreement on how AI is used in the team – the Five Agreements (Tools, Data, Review, Disclosure, and Direction and Support) plus descriptions of important recurring workflows.

Align's job across this module is to turn scattered differences into that one standard: a short, explicit agreement on the things that affect everyone. By the end of Align, the standard is what you walk away with.

4 The path through the module

The module builds it across four lessons. **First**, why setting the standard has to be your call at all – because leaving AI use to each person no longer holds. **Then** two build lessons: Layer 1, the five agreements every team needs; and Layer 2, how AI fits the actual recurring work your team does together. **Finally**, putting the standard into practice – so it becomes how people work, not a document nobody reads.

That path asks something new of you: not making every AI call for your people, but setting up the frame they work within.

> WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON
>
> - Treat the Team AI Baseline as a **starting point, not a result** – differences seen are not differences settled.
> - Separate the two kinds of decisions: professional judgment in the work stays individual; matters that affect everyone need **one shared answer**.
> - Aim for one standard agreed once, with the whole team – not a series of one-to-one fixes.
> - Expect the frame-setting to be yours: the standard has to be **set, not left to chance**.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working – this module turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. **Next: Lesson 3.2 – Why "Use AI If You Want" No Longer Works** – why setting this standard has to be the manager's call at all.

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Why "Use AI If You Want" No Longer Works

Why can I no longer leave these choices entirely to individual team members?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 2 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Decision lesson · 8–10 min

THE CORE IDEA

AI choices shape the value the team captures, the capabilities people develop, the support they receive, and the risks the team carries.

That is why "use AI if you want" is no longer enough — and why the decision has become yours.

1 The instinct that got you here

How your team uses AI today was shaped partly by a management instinct that is usually right: trust capable people to find the best way to do their work. That instinct belongs in the **judgment of the work** — how to frame a problem, what trade-offs to weigh, what to recommend — and it stays there. But AI widens what one person's judgment touches: paste sensitive client data into a chatbot, and the whole team carries the risk; build a decision on an AI figure nobody checked, and everyone owns the result.

2 The decisions it leaves unmade

AI adds decisions of a different kind — the **shared conditions** around everyone's work: **where AI creates value worth supporting**, **which capabilities people must retain**, **whether access and support are fair**, **which tools and data are acceptable**, and **when output needs review and AI involvement should be visible**.

"Use AI if you want" sounds like trust, but it leaves each person to settle these alone — answers diverge, useful practices stay isolated, capability develops unevenly. The team fragments instead of compounds.

3 Why the decision lands on you

Some of these questions may already be answered above you. Where rules exist, use them; where unclear, ask; where absent, push the question up — don't write company-wide policy from inside your team. But rules can't cover everything; those calls are made close to the work. However much guidance you get, **how AI is used in your team comes back to you**.

4 Five risks that build when the decisions go unmade

Data security & compliance

Paste a document into an unvetted tool and the information leaves for an outside service under terms nobody read — and nobody decided it could.

Accountability

AI output arrives with no formulas and no revision history. When a wrong figure reaches a client, no one can show how the work was made.

Quality & consistency

The same tool gives one person a sharp draft and another confident nonsense. Quality under your name swings with whoever produced it; good practice stays locked in a few heads.

Capability

When AI handles the drafting and first-pass thinking, those muscles get used less. Lose the expertise and you lose the people who can tell whether AI output is any good.

Talent & fairness

People who got a head start with AI pull ahead for the wrong reasons. Left alone, the gap hardens – and you end up promoting access to AI rather than ability.

Plenty of AI use is perfectly fine – the risk is in what goes **unmanaged**. Each of these five traces back to a shared condition nobody settled, and lands on the team first, the organization soon after.

5 New work – and your opening

Past system rollouts were someone else's process: IT scoped them, training was organized centrally, you adopted what was handed down. AI did not arrive that way – the discovery and alignment happen close to the work, with you leading. That work is new. It is also your opening: Harvard Business Review research on AI adoption found that the **middle layer of management** – not the technology, not the executive vision – is where adoption actually succeeds or fails. Managers who lead this layer elevate too – the visible point where AI turns into real team performance. Not extra work bolted onto your role: your role, changing.

Julia Shin and Sandra J. Sucher, "AI Adoption Is Overloading Your Middle Managers," Harvard Business Review.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Keep professional judgment with the team – the reframe is about the **scope of the decision**, not trust.
- Stop offering "use AI if you want" as trust – it hands people a team-level decision they can't make alone.
- Apply the rules that exist, ask where unclear, escalate where absent – and own the rest.
- Settle the five shared conditions once, visibly – without prescribing every individual use.
- Change the stance first: these decisions are yours to lead.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working – this module turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. **Next: Lesson 3.3 – How to Build the Team Working Standard – Layer 1** – the five agreements, built with your team in one focused conversation.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

How to Build the Team Working Standard – Layer 1

What does a team standard actually cover?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 3 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

Layer 1 turns the findings from Assess into five shared expectations for using AI well as a team.

Five questions, one focused conversation, one page – shaped with the team, owned by you.

1 One standard, two layers

The **Team Working Standard** has two layers. **Layer 1 – shared expectations:** five minimum agreements that turn the shared conditions into a working document. **Layer 2 – workflows that include AI:** how recurring tasks get done with AI in the process (next lesson).

Organization-level AI guidelines, where they exist, don't tell your team how to work with AI on its everyday tasks. Layer 1 is the team-level version: just enough to change daily behavior. Not a policy handed down – shaped with the team, owned by the manager.

2 Two ways the standard goes wrong

Too big: every scenario, tool, and edge case – comprehensive on paper, ignored in practice. **Too small:** "we use Copilot for drafts and review before sending" – one tool, one review habit; data open, disclosure unstated, direction undefined. What works answers the five questions most teams must resolve first – nothing more.

3 The Five Agreements

Tools – what may be used

Which AI tools are approved, which are not, and how a new tool gets considered. One shared answer instead of individual tool choices.

Data – what may be entered

Clear categories of what stays out, plus one rule that survives time pressure: **when in doubt, leave it out**. Follow the organization's actual data rules – *private* does not mean anything goes.

Review – what must receive human judgment

Which AI-assisted work needs a human look before it is used or shared – internal and client-facing may differ. This is the minimum; workflow detail comes in Layer 2.

Disclosure – when AI involvement must be visible

Not every prompt – only the cases where knowing AI was involved would change how a manager, colleague, or client reads the work. Useful visibility, not surveillance.

Direction and Support – where the team is going, what people need

Where AI should create value, which capabilities must stay strong, what support people need to take part. One or two sentences — not a mission statement or a training plan.

4 Before the session: separate fixed from open

If the organization has mandated a tool, Agreement 1 is pre-answered — name it and move on: **a mandate decides the tool, not the standard**. If guidance is partial or absent, don't treat silence as approval: use what exists, set conservative interim boundaries, and take open questions to whoever owns them. Review, disclosure, and direction and support don't need to wait. The principle: fix what is fixed, set interim boundaries, build what is within your authority, escalate the rest.

Then frame the session: **not a restriction on AI use** — a framework for using it well. The team's input shapes the answers; fixed constraints stay fixed; where something stays stuck or carries real risk, you make the call after the team is heard.

5 One conversation, one page

THE SESSION IN THREE STEPS

1. **Review the Team AI Baseline together** — patterns across the team, not individual responses. Let people react before deciding.
2. **Build the five agreements one by one** — start from any fixed constraint, then ask: *"Within that boundary, what answer will work for this team?"* One or two sentences each.
3. **Read it back and write it down** — check the wording says what was agreed, log what must go up to IT or Legal, circulate the clean draft.

Note: imperfect is fine — a short follow-up can fix anything unclear.

The output is one page: five sections, one or two sentences each. The discussion will be richer than the document — that is right: write down the decisions, not the reasoning. Not a policy — a **working agreement**, revisited with the team quarterly. Step one, not the finish line: Layer 2 adds how recurring tasks run with AI inside them.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Resist the policy instinct — build the standard **with the team**, at team level.
- Keep it to the five agreements — answer them and stop.
- Separate fixed constraints from team decisions before the session — silence is not approval.
- Hold the line: everyone's input shapes the answers; the final call stays with you.
- Leave with something written — one page the team can put to work.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working — this module turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. **Next: Lesson 3.4 — How to Build the Team Working Standard — Layer 2** — taking the five agreements into the work itself.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

How to Build the Team Working Standard – Layer 2

How should our recurring work happen with AI in it?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 4 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

The five agreements set shared expectations. The workflow descriptions give recurring work a shared shape. Together they form the Team Working Standard.

Make the current process visible first – then change it only where it doesn't meet the team's agreements.

1 Clear agreement, five interpretations

Take your review agreement: client-facing AI-assisted work needs human review. Clear – but hand it to five people and you get five interpretations: different things checked, at different moments, different ideas of who owns the final call. A **workflow description** closes that gap: one repeatable reference for how the work actually runs – what gets reviewed, when, and by whom – mostly by making how the work already runs explicit.

2 What counts as a workflow

Every team runs on the same logic: something comes in, work happens, something goes out. A workflow is one recurring sequence of that kind – identifiable steps, a clear input, a defined output. Its description answers: what starts the task, where AI enters, what information it uses, what it produces, where human judgment or verification occurs, and who remains accountable. Describe **what people do, not which tool they use** – the description stays accurate when the tool changes.

3 Do you need workflow descriptions at all?

Two questions decide. **Do multiple people do the same task? Is the output high-stakes** – going to a client, informing a decision, carrying real risk? If neither, the five agreements are enough for now. If at least one is yes, describe **two or three workflows** – not all: the ones where AI is already in the work and the stakes are highest.

4 The four-step workflow method

Step 1 – Select the workflow

The strongest candidates: AI is already involved, and the output matters. Ask which two or three tasks have changed most since AI arrived; pick one and anchor it in a recent, specific example.

Step 2 – Draw the current process

Map the task start to finish: what starts it, what happens next, where AI is already involved, what happens before the output is shared. One line, step by step, is enough – mark AI steps, judgment, verification.

Step 3 – Run one Five Agreements check

Once, across the completed map: **Tools** (which tool, where) · **Data** (what enters it) · **Review** (where judgment and verification occur) · **Disclosure** (when involvement must be visible, to whom) · **Direction and Support**

(what value AI adds, which capabilities the work still needs, what support people need). Add whatever the check shows is missing.

Step 4 – Finalize the process flow

Update the map with what was agreed; mark AI steps, human judgment, verification, decisions, and ownership; confirm it with the people who do the work. **The finalized flow is the workflow description.**

Two special cases: an **agentic tool** – AI taking a broader goal through several steps before you see a result – needs added lines for what it can access, what it must not do, and where a person reviews before the output moves on. Pending tool approval: map what the team may currently use and mark proposed AI steps as pending.

5 Draft it with AI, check it with the team

You don't have to write it up yourself: paste your notes and finalized flow into an approved AI tool for the clean written version – then check it against what was decided and correct anything wrong. Share the draft while the discussion is fresh, for one round of input: anything wrong, missing, or unclear? A check, not a vote – the manager remains accountable for the final standard.

With the checked workflow descriptions added to the five agreements, the **Team Working Standard is complete** – Layer 1 and Layer 2, one document. Complete is not yet active; that is the next lesson's job.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Start where AI is already in the work and the output matters – **two or three workflows**, never all.
- Make the current process visible **before** deciding whether it changes – documenting a sound practice is a valid outcome.
- Run the Five Agreements check once, across the whole map – not five checks per step.
- Let AI draft the write-up, but check it against the decisions before it circulates.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working – this module turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. Download with this lesson: Handout C – Workflow Template. **Next: Lesson 3.5 – Putting the Team Working Standard into Practice** – making the completed standard active, and keeping it that way.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Putting the Team Working Standard into Practice

How do I make the standard actually stick?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 5 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Action lesson · 6–8 min

THE CORE IDEA

A standard only matters when it changes behavior.

It becomes real the first time you reference it in real work, it sticks because you keep referencing it, and one quarterly question keeps it current.

1 Complete is not active

Most standards fail right at completion — not because they were wrong, but because the manager treated completion as adoption: the document existed, the work felt done, the work went back to normal. The step between complete and real is **activation** — not a second event, but a small set of moves made from completion onward. Making them, or skipping them, decides whether the standard holds or drifts.

2 Three ways a completed standard fails

It becomes invisible

Saved in a shared folder, linked once, never mentioned again. Technically available — but nothing in daily work surfaces it. Within a month, asking about it would feel like a quiz.

It stays manager-held

Only the manager remembers it or interprets what applies. When a new situation comes up, the team waits to be told what the standard says instead of using it as a shared reference.

It goes stale

This one arrives by time, not neglect. Tools change, tasks evolve — six months later the standard still names the previous tool, and people adjust individually: the exact fragmentation the standard was built to prevent.

All three are preventable — through activation, and one recurring check.

3 Activation: three elements

First, place it where work happens — pinned in the team's main channel, linked in the project tool. Not in a folder; in the flow. This prevents the invisibility failure.

Second, name how it will be used — a short framing that positions the document as a working tool, not a policy, and gives the team explicit permission to flag problems. That permission prevents the manager-held failure.

Third, use it in the work — and keep using it. The element the first two exist for, and the one most managers skip. An announcement tells the team the standard exists; a **reference** tells them it applies — to real work, in a real decision. Bring it in at the live moments the work hands you — a review, a handoff, a one-to-one — and ask

how it applies. The first reference starts the habit; consistent reference turns the standard into infrastructure. (Catching every error is the Checkpoint Map's job, next module.)

TWO SENTENCES THAT DO THE WORK

1. **Naming the shift:** *"This is now our shared standard for how we work with AI. We'll use it in reviews, handoffs, onboarding, and whenever something is unclear. If something comes up that it doesn't cover, or something in it stops working, bring it to me. We'll update it."*
2. **Referencing it in live work:** *"Our standard says anything going to a client gets a human read-through. Walk me through your review here."*

4 Keeping the standard current

The whole maintenance mechanism is one question, once a quarter: *"Is anything in this standard no longer working, unclear, or outdated?"* Five minutes at the end of a team meeting. If yes, update; if no, move on – the date at the top changes, and the team knows it's current.

A revisit comes sooner when a **new AI tool** arrives or an existing one changes significantly, the **team's work changes** – new clients, task types, or risk areas – or a **re-run of the AI Baseline Assessment** shows the standard is no longer followed in practice.

One distinction: the quarterly check handles **collective drift**. One person consistently working outside the standard is a coaching conversation – later, under Lead – not a standard failure.

5 What you've built

Align has kept its promise. Assess gave you the picture – the **Team AI Baseline** – and Align turned it into the **Team Working Standard**, agreed with your team where before each person decided alone. That foundation is what the rest of the course builds on. Next: keeping the work safe, with checkpoints that catch problems before they reach a client or a decision.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Put the standard **in the flow of work**, not in a folder.
- Name the shift out loud once – working tool, not policy, with permission to flag problems.
- Reference the standard in live work – the first reference starts the habit, repetition makes it infrastructure.
- Ask the one quarterly question and change the date at the top.
- Collective drift updates the standard; individual drift is a coaching conversation for later.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working – the module that turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. Download with this lesson: Handout D – Quarterly Review. **Next: Module 4, Lesson 4.1 – When AI Errors Become Business Decisions** – the Control move begins: putting checks where the risk enters the work.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

When AI Errors Become Business Decisions

What happens when AI gets it wrong and nobody catches it?

MODULE 4 · LESSON 1 | CONTROL: CONFIDENCE | Decision lesson · 8–10 min

THE CORE IDEA

AI risk becomes real when nobody owns verification.

Caught in the document, an error is an edit. Caught after the decision, it's a commitment you have to live with.

1 From a standard to a control

Align gave you a shared standard for how your team works with AI. But a standard says how work *should* be done — not that it actually is. Closing that gap is the job of **Control**, the framework's third move: Control puts the checks where the risk enters the work. Its output is the **Checkpoint Map** — verification moments placed inside your team's workflows, protecting your data, your decisions, and outside trust. This lesson names the first risk that map has to address.

2 An error that becomes a decision

A piece of work lands in your inbox — a competitive analysis, a briefing, a business case. It reads well; the data points are specific: percentages, figures, named sources. You review it, edit, send it on. Three days later someone chases one of the figures — and it doesn't exist. Neither does the study it was cited from. Caught there, the error is an edit. Now put the discovery three months later, after approval, once resource allocation has begun: the figure justified the investment, commitments are in place, and the error is no longer in a document — it is in a plan. That is where this risk lives: not in the wrong output, but in what happens when it reaches a decision before anyone checks it.

3 Why the error travels

You already know AI produces confidently wrong output with no signal that something is wrong. What matters here is what that output does next: **it moves**. A team member trusts it — nothing in the work gave them a reason not to — and it travels down a chain of hands toward a business case or a leadership presentation, each person assuming the previous one had checked the key claims. Nobody had, because a verification moment was never explicitly placed anywhere in the chain.

That is structural, not bad luck. Fluency and accuracy are independent in AI output, so a wrong answer looks identical to a correct one — and we trust output that looks authoritative: specific, confident, well-formatted. The result is an asymmetry: errors enter the work quickly; their consequences take far longer to unwind.

4 Normal review isn't built for this

The question isn't whether your team is diligent. Normal review catches errors that *look* like errors — poor logic, thin evidence, an argument that doesn't hold together. It is not designed to catch a fabricated statistic that reads exactly like a real one, attributed to a real source. The reframe: **AI-generated information moving toward a decision is a different category of risk** than the same information in a draft or an internal note. Treating them the same is what lets errors travel.

So before work informs a decision, one thing must be clear: who checks the key claims. That doesn't have to be you – your job is to make sure there is a someone, with a name. The Team AI Baseline shows where AI is in the work; the standard's review agreement gives it a second pair of eyes. Neither one names that person.

TERM – CHECKPOINT

A named verification moment inside a workflow, written as **When → What → Who** – the moment, the check, the owner. It is the piece this module adds; the Checkpoint Map is the output of Control.

5 The first diagnostic

Not the Checkpoint Map yet – that comes in Lesson 4.3. For now, one diagnostic move: read any AI-assisted work headed for a decision with three questions in mind.

THREE QUESTIONS TO HOLD IN MIND

1. **What is the key claim this decision rests on?** The one figure, benchmark, or conclusion that, if wrong, would change the decision.
2. **Where did that claim come from – AI, or a verified source?** Open the citation: does the source actually support the claim?
3. **Who verified it before it reached me?** You'll usually have to ask. If the answer is "nobody" – or "I assumed someone had" – that is the gap.

A diagnostic, not a system: start asking these – first of your own incoming work, then of how work moves through the team. Where question three keeps coming back "nobody," you've located a gap the Checkpoint Map will need to close. For now, the move is to notice.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Treat AI-assisted work heading toward a decision as a **different risk category** than drafts and internal notes.
- Assign verification ownership – make sure one **named person** checks the key claims before work informs a decision. You don't verify everything yourself.
- This week, run the three questions on one real document that informed – or could have informed – a decision. Use the actual document and its sources, not your memory of it.
- Write down where the verification moment was – or wasn't. Don't fix anything yet; those notes are raw material for the Checkpoint Map.

Module 4 · Control: Confidence – this module puts the checks where the risk enters the work; its output is the Checkpoint Map.
Next: Lesson 4.2 – AI Risk Goes Beyond Wrong Answers – the risks that aren't about quality at all: your data, your exposure, and the trust of people outside the team.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

AI Risk Goes Beyond Wrong Answers

What else can go wrong beyond bad AI output?

MODULE 4 · LESSON 2 | CONTROL: CONFIDENCE | Decision lesson · 6–8 min

THE CORE IDEA

Output quality is only one category of AI risk.

Risk also enters with what your team puts into AI tools — and with what leaves the team and reaches people outside it.

1 One risk named, two to go

The last lesson named the first risk the Checkpoint Map must address: a wrong answer reaching a decision unchecked stops being a document problem and becomes a commitment you have to live with. This lesson names two more — what goes *into* AI tools, and what comes *out* and reaches people outside the team. Three risks complete the picture of where AI risk actually enters.

2 Risk two — sensitive data goes in before anyone asks

Someone on your team, stuck on a client proposal's executive summary, pastes it into an AI tool for a better opening — it works, they submit on time. They weren't being reckless; they were doing their job. But that one paste may have moved a document carrying your client's name and your proposed approach outside the protections you assume are in place — no warning, and it can repeat quietly, piece after piece.

Most people use AI tools like a search engine: something in, something out, contained. But AI tools are **work systems** — account settings, vendor terms, retention rules — and what happens to entered information depends on a setup most team members never thought to check. And the deeper problem sits before the configuration question: nobody asked whether the document should go in at all. The data agreement in your Team Working Standard already names what goes into AI tools and what doesn't — but **knowing a rule and reaching the moment that triggers it are two different things**. Without that moment, the rule gets applied when people remember it: inconsistently, under pressure, not by default.

3 Risk three — AI errors reach external audiences

The third risk is on the way out. A client finds an error in a deliverable — a figure that doesn't match the source data, traced to an unchecked AI-generated section. You correct it, they accept. Then, at the next kickoff, a new request: can drafts come two days earlier, so they can run their own fact-check? That is the reputational consequence. Not a lost contract — a quiet shift: the client now plans around the chance that your work is wrong, and you'll probably never hear about it again.

This risk is different in kind. An error that stays inside the team is **operational** — correctable, revisitable. An error that reaches people outside it is **relational** — trust is slower to rebuild than a document is to fix. And it's broader than accuracy: external work can also fail by not fitting the client, the relationship, or the context. The review agreement in your standard already names which work needs human judgment before it's used or shared; what no rule names is the moment — where that review happens, by whom, checking what.

4 Three risks, three controls

Three risks, entering at different moments, causing different kinds of damage – and the rules for each already exist. But rules tell people *what* to do, not *when*. And *when* is where the risk enters.

Decisions
AI errors heading for a decision need a **verification moment** before the work gets there.

Data
Sensitive data entering AI tools needs a **check before content goes in** – not after.

External output
Work going to clients, partners, other departments, or public audiences needs a **different review standard** than internal work – because the consequence of error is different.

These aren't AI's only risks – capability and fairness are people questions the course returns to later; these three are the ones a checkpoint can directly guard against. And a checkpoint is small: a named moment, a minutes-long check, one owner – one question before pasting, one source opened before approval, one sharper read before it leaves. That is the shift from a rule the team knows to a control that holds.

5 The checkpoint scan

This week, run this on the places you already know AI sits in the team's work – the Baseline, the mapped workflows.

SCAN THREE AREAS – IS THERE A CHECK, AND IS IT NAMED?

1. **Decisions.** Where AI-assisted work feeds a decision: is anyone named to verify the key claims before it gets there?
2. **Data.** Where sensitive material could go into a tool: is there a moment where someone asks "should this go in?" – or does it rely on people remembering?
3. **External output.** Where work leaves the team: does it get a sharper check than internal work – or the same one?

Nothing gets fixed yet. The task is finding the spots where the answer is "nobody" or "nothing" – those gaps are the raw material the next lesson turns into the Checkpoint Map.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Stop treating output quality as the whole risk picture – watch **what goes into tools** and **what leaves the team**, too.
- Hold external work to a sharper review than internal work – internal errors are operational, external ones are relational.
- When you spot a risk, resist the instinct to just re-tighten the rules – place a **moment** where the rule takes effect.
- Run the three-area scan this week and note every check that has no name on it.

Module 4 · Control: Confidence – this module puts the checks where the risk enters the work; its output is the Checkpoint Map.
Next: Lesson 4.3 – Build and Activate the Checkpoint Map – turning the gaps you've found into named checkpoints that hold inside real work.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Build and Activate the Checkpoint Map

How do I build and activate checkpoints that protect the work?

MODULE 4 · LESSON 3 | CONTROL: CONFIDENCE | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

Control works best when embedded into normal work — not added afterward.

A rule the team knows is not a control. A specific moment where the right question gets asked — consistently — is.

1 Two shortcuts that don't work

Two shortcuts tempt most managers: telling the team about the risks and trusting awareness to change behavior (mid-workday, it won't — not reliably), or writing the checks into a shared document and calling it done (under pressure, nobody remembers to consult it). The Checkpoint Map is different: the map is only the record — the control is each question **anchored to its moment in the work**, asked without anyone having to remember. The plan: build, activate, check it's working, keep it current.

2 What the Checkpoint Map is

TERM — CHECKPOINT MAP

The output of Control: named verification moments embedded in team workflows, each written as **When → What → Who** — the moment a risk is likely to appear, the check that catches it, and the person responsible for asking.

A complete map for one area of work — a client briefing:

Confirm no client data will be used in AI prompts
When: before drafting begins · **Who:** the team member

Verify figures and benchmarks against confirmed sources
When: before the outline is finalized · **Who:** the team member

Second-person read-through: tone, accuracy, appropriateness
When: before the draft goes to the client · **Who:** a colleague

3 Two entry points

If the team's workflows aren't written down, **start from where you see risk** — the moments this module's scans already surfaced — and write a checkpoint for each; three or four standalone lines is enough. If key workflows or SOPs are documented, **start from those**: walk each one, ask where risk enters — data going in, output feeding a decision, work going external — and hang a checkpoint on every yes. Both work; the second scales best for shared recurring processes.

4 The build: three questions per area of work

Either way, the build is the same — done with the people who do the work; the moments belong to them.

THREE BUILD QUESTIONS

1. **Where could AI-related risk enter – and reach a consequence?** Not where AI is used generally; where something going wrong would matter.
2. **At that moment, what is the simplest check?** One question, under two minutes – your data and review agreements usually already say what must be true. Too complex to be done isn't a control.
3. **Who applies it?** Name the person. Named accountability makes the check happen; assumed accountability means it probably won't.

Agentic AI: an agent takes a sequence of actions, not just an output, so risk can appear *during* the process. Two boundary checks – before it starts: what is it allowed to do, and not? After it finishes: can we see what it did? If actions are hard to undo, the before-check is critical.

Write each answer as one line – **When** → **What** → **Who**. That is the Checkpoint Map.

5 Activation: four things

Where it lives
In the flow of work – the same shared space as the Team Working Standard. Not in a folder.

How it's introduced
A document the team **confirms**, not a policy they receive; the manager holds the line when a check gets skipped.

The first time it's used
It becomes real the first time a checkpoint is asked in real work: *"Before this goes out – have we run the source check?"*

Consistency and accountability
Same checks, same moments, every time – and everyone knows which check is theirs.

6 Check it's working – and keep it current

Your part is not running the checks – it is **checking that they run**: *"Before this went out – did we run the source check?"* When the answer is no, ask what happened – unclear checkpoint, skipped under pressure, or wrong place? – to learn, not to blame. Then one quarterly question, alongside the standard's check-in: *"Are these checkpoints still working – and still in the right places?"* Revisit sooner when an error gets through, a new tool arrives, or an agent enters the work – and when something goes wrong, ask not "why did this happen?" but **"at which moment was the checkpoint missing?"**

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Build the map with your team – one recurring AI-involved task first.
- Write every checkpoint as one line – **When** → **What** → **Who** – and keep each check under two minutes.
- Put the map where the team works, share it as a draft to confirm – then activate it out loud with the first real checkpoint question.
- Check that checks run, and use the quarterly question to keep the map in the right places.

Module 4 · Control: Confidence – the moments, the checks, and the owners that protect decisions, data, and outside trust.
Next: Module 5 · Lesson 5.1 – Why People Resist AI – and Why Forcing It Doesn't Work – the Lead move begins.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Why People Resist AI — and Why Forcing It Doesn't Work

Why aren't people just using AI if it's clearly useful?

MODULE 5 · LESSON 1 | LEAD: CAPABILITY | Decision lesson · 8–10 min

THE CORE IDEA

Resistance is feedback — not refusal.

It reveals conditions you can manage, not attitudes you have to override.

1 Structure doesn't create adoption

The last module left you with three pieces of structure — the **Team AI Baseline**, the **Team Working Standard**, and the **Checkpoint Map**. But structure doesn't create adoption on its own: people have to use the tools, trust the output, and grow with AI. That's an adoption problem more than an AI one — and answering it is the **Lead** move: Lead turns the standard into durable capability, through four roles built one lesson at a time.

2 Resistance is rarely what it looks like

Stalled adoption doesn't look like one thing: someone slower and quiet who says it's fine; a tool mandate from above to cascade down; or metrics that look right while real adoption is stalled. The instinct in every case is to push. But if a person is holding back because of an unspoken concern, more pressure won't surface it — it will bury it.

3 Four concerns behind apparent resistance

Job security

Worried that being good at AI makes them dispensable. Never said directly — it shows up as low engagement, quiet compliance, or minimizing what AI can do.

Competence identity

Their reputation is built on doing certain work well; using AI feels like admitting they can't do it without help. Not incompetence — the opposite: someone who cares about their professional standard.

Skill gap anxiety

They don't know the tools well and feel they should. Asking for help would expose the gap — so they try quietly, get mediocre results, and hold back.

Distrust of the output

They've seen AI produce wrong or flat output and won't put their name on work they can't stand behind. Not irrational — a professional standard.

These four aren't exhaustive — **task fit** or a **capability gap** can look the same from outside. What they share: none is a motivation problem, so a clearer expectation addresses the wrong thing. The first move is always the same: find out which one you're dealing with.

4 Why mandating makes it worse

TERM – COMPLIANCE THEATER

Activity that looks like adoption but doesn't prove real capability or useful change – boxes checked, positive one-to-ones, output quietly ignored and rewritten by hand.

A mandate piles pressure on a concern you haven't understood yet, so it goes underground: the person starts managing how their AI use *looks* to you instead of telling you what's in the way. Resistance isn't a refusal you can override – it's information, and a mandate hides exactly the information you need.

THE ALTERNATIVE: ONE DIAGNOSTIC QUESTION

1. Instead of *"are you using AI?"*, ask in a one-to-one: **"What are you finding difficult about using AI, or is there anything about the tools that isn't working for you?"**

Note: an example, not a script – the move is the conversation around it: it signals difficulty is discussable and gives you real information.

5 What actually drives adoption: the four roles

Diagnosing the barrier is where adoption starts, not where it ends – you lead a whole team, over time, and none of what stalls it announces itself. The Lead move runs on four ongoing roles:

Reinforce

A new way of working won't hold on its own – when your attention moves on, it drifts back. Reinforce keeps it alive with deliberate, repeated signals.

Develop

Your people are not in the same place, and the same nudge that moves one sets another back. Develop reads where each person is and agrees a specific next step.

Amplify

Learning doesn't spread by itself – one person's discovery stays locked in their head. Amplify surfaces it, pressure-tests it, spreads it, and makes it stick.

Scout

Standing still is falling behind. Scout deliberately looks for where AI could add value next, and tests it in a bounded way before it becomes how everyone operates.

None of these is a mandate. They're not pressure – they're management: the ordinary work of leading a team through change.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Read resistance as **information** – diagnose the specific barrier before you respond.
- Retire the mandate reflex: pressure on an unnamed concern buries it and buys you compliance theater.
- Ask the diagnostic question in a real one-to-one, and let the answer set your response.
- Treat adoption as ongoing management through the four roles, not a one-time fix.

Module 5 · Lead: Capability – the module that turns the standard into durable capability. **Next: Lesson 5.2 – Reinforce – Building and Sustaining Adoption** – keeping the agreed way of working alive after the rollout.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Reinforce — Building and Sustaining Adoption

How do I keep the team's agreed way of working visible and active over time?

MODULE 5 · LESSON 2 | LEAD: CAPABILITY | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

Repeated manager signals make desired ways of working more likely to continue.

Reinforcement reduces drift — it doesn't create adoption by itself.

1 Drift is the default

You've built the structure, and for the first time there's nothing new to set up. This is the moment most managers step back — and in the months that follow, teams quietly drift. Not because anyone gave up: old habits are easier, and busy weeks pull people back toward what they know. The counterweight is your attention — the team reads what you keep asking about, recognizing, and modeling as the real signal of what matters. Stop referring to the new way of working, and old habits come back. So does the silence.

Reinforce is the answer: not another document or meeting, but steady signals woven into interactions already happening — kickoffs, reviews, one-to-ones. It works in two directions: keeping what you've built working, and keeping the team ready for what's coming. Not a phase of the rollout — a standing part of the job.

2 Four levers, four kinds of signal

Reinforce runs on four levers: what you point the team at, what you praise, what you ask about, and what you do yourself.

Vision — say what AI is for

Keep the team's agreed statement alive by saying it in real work moments: *"We use AI to spend less time on first drafts and more time on client thinking."* Add the longer horizon — where AI's role is heading in six to twelve months — pitched at the team's output (products, clients, process), not individual tasks.

Recognition — name the good calls

Praise the *how*, not just the result: someone double-checking an AI answer, or a smart call about when not to trust it. "Good work" tells people nothing — naming the behavior shows everyone what good looks like. Say it in front of the team when it fits; check they're comfortable first.

Asking — ask how the work gets done

What you ask about tells the team what you care about. Swap *"how did it go?"* for *"how did you approach this?"* — then: what did you use AI for, where was the judgment call, where did you check the output, what would you do differently? No new meeting needed.

Modeling — go first yourself

People watch what you do more than what you say. If you want the team to use AI — and to be open about where it's hard — they have to see you doing both.

3 Modeling has two beats

At the start, show your own rough edges: a real attempt that took four tries, and what you learned. If you rarely use AI, don't fake it – pick one real task, try it, and report honestly. The point is to show that struggling is normal, you included; when you say it first, the team learns they're allowed to say it too.

Over time, shift from "I got it wrong" to "here's when I decided *not* to trust it, and why." If you only model success, the team learns struggling isn't allowed. Modeling judgment – when to use AI, when not to, what to double-check – is the real skill.

A QUICK SELF-SCAN OF THE FOUR LEVERS

1. **Vision** – do I say out loud what AI is for, and where we're heading with it, in real work moments?
2. **Recognition** – when someone makes a smart call with AI, do I name it?
3. **Asking** – do I ask how people worked, or only whether it got done?
4. **Modeling** – have I recently shown the team my own AI use, and how it actually went?

Then: pick the lever you're weakest on and use it once this week, in one real conversation or meeting. That scan is the first entry in your **Lead AI Adoption Plan** – a running record of how you lead adoption, built one lesson at a time.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Don't step back once the structure is built – drift is the default, and your attention is the counterweight.
- Recognize the specific behavior you want more of: verification, judgment, honest experiments.
- Ask *"how did you approach this?"* and let the answers show you how work actually gets made.
- Go first on difficulty, then graduate to modeling judgment.

Module 5 · Lead: Capability – the module that turns the standard into durable capability. **Next: Lesson 5.3 – Develop – Moving Each Person Forward** – a different role: moving each person forward, one at a time.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Develop — Moving Each Person Forward

How do I help each person take the right next step in their development?

MODULE 5 · LESSON 3 | LEAD: CAPABILITY | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

Development improves when you read where each person is, agree one step that fits, and adjust together.

Positions are starting reads, not fixed labels — people move between them as they learn.

1 One team, four different places

Every person on your team is somewhere different with AI. One has been experimenting for months. Another does exactly what's expected — no more. A third is holding back. A fourth is genuinely trying, failing, and losing confidence. One shared team message can't address four different development needs. **Develop** is individual work: move each person forward from where they actually are — not at the same pace, in the same direction, or with the same response. The way in is the **Asking** lever from Reinforce: it surfaces what each person is trying, what's working, and where they've stalled.

2 The three-step Develop sequence

However different your people are, you move each one forward the same way, one person at a time, usually in a one-to-one: **Step 1 — Understand** where the person is with AI. **Step 2 — Agree a next step** — one concrete task that fits. **Step 3 — Follow up and adjust**.

3 Step 1: read where they are

You're not starting from zero — the **Team AI Baseline** from Assess gave you a first picture of each person. But that was a snapshot, and people move. The real read happens in conversation: when a one-to-one gets to AI, open with **"Walk me through how you've been using AI on your work recently."** Not *"are you using AI?"* — that gets a yes or no. Listen for four patterns:

Exploring
Ahead of the team, brings up examples unprompted, asking what's next.

Complying
Does it, but vague — no real examples, low energy.

Resisting
Hesitation, "it doesn't really fit my work," pauses.

Struggling
Tried it, it didn't work, confidence dropping.

These are starting guesses, not fixed labels. And someone who's simply doing well needs no pattern: name it, agree a step that keeps them going, move on.

4 Step 2: agree one step that fits

Help the person commit to at least one concrete step – specific and agreed, not a vague "use AI more." The step must fit where they are, because the same nudge that helps one person harms another. **Exploring**: stretch them and make their work visible – *"What have you figured out that the rest of the team doesn't know yet?"* **Complying**: connect AI to something they'd like to change – *"What part of your work do you wish took less time?"* **Resisting**: surface the concern first; pushing buries it – *"What's making this feel uncertain for you – specifically?"* **Struggling**: go smaller – one task they can win at – *"Where exactly does it break down for you?"*

Before you close, run the **three-part step test**: can you both say what they'll try, on what work, and when you'll talk about how it went? If not, it isn't a step yet. The full set – signals, questions, task ideas – is on the **Develop Reference Card**; glance at it before a one-to-one.

5 Step 3: follow up and adjust

Go back to the exact step and ask what they tried, what worked, and what they'd do differently. The answers tell you two things – how the person is doing, and whether your read was right. A step that doesn't land is **information, not failure**: recalibrate together. Follow up sooner when someone is blocked, losing confidence, or the work carries risk. And name what this is: coaching – a skill you already have, pointed at a new subject.

RUN THE SEQUENCE ONCE THIS WEEK

1. **Before:** pick one person and guess their position loosely – the Team AI Baseline gives a head start. Keep the Reference Card nearby.
2. **During:** open with the walk-me-through question, listen for the patterns, agree one step, set the check-back.
3. **After:** jot it into your **Lead AI Adoption Plan** – position, evidence, agreed step, follow-up date. The first row of your Develop entry.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Meet each person where they actually are – retire the single team message as a development tool.
- Open the AI part of one-to-ones with *"walk me through…"*, not *"are you using AI?"*
- Hold every read loosely, and let follow-up evidence confirm or correct it.
- Close no conversation without the three-part step test passing.

Module 5 · Lead: Capability – the module that turns the standard into durable capability. Download with this lesson: **Handout A – Develop Reference Card**. **Next: Lesson 5.4 – Amplify – Building Collective Capability** – turning what one person learns into capability the whole team keeps.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Amplify – Building Collective Capability

How do I turn one person's useful finding into bounded, reusable team knowledge?

MODULE 5 · LESSON 4 | LEAD: CAPABILITY | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

Individual learning becomes team capability only when it is surfaced, examined, spread, and retained.

Sharing alone isn't enough – a tip can be misunderstood, overgeneralized, forgotten, or left with the same few people.

1 Learning stays private by default

On many teams, people using AI are still learning partly on their own. One person has worked out something that gets consistently better results – few colleagues know. Another has found AI useful for one stage of the process and unreliable for another – never discussed. A third tried something that failed and moved on – so someone else will repeat the attempt. The **Amplify** role turns what one person learns into something the team can use, in four steps: **Surface** → **Examine** → **Spread** → **Retain**.

2 Surface: get it said out loud

Most AI learning never is. The easiest way in is a conversation you're already having – a one-to-one, a task discussion – where you hear something and think: that might be worth something for the team. On top of that, put one recurring question into a meeting you already have: **"Has anyone learned something about using AI since we last asked – something that worked, something that didn't, something worth sharing?"** Go first, and share something real – including a failure; failures rarely get volunteered, but they're often the most useful thing in the room. Push past speed tips toward **judgment**: where someone didn't trust the output, where AI broke down, what they changed. Learning picked up outside – a course, a community, a conference – feeds the same sequence. And silence doesn't mean nothing's there: try collecting findings in writing, or ask one person ahead of time.

3 Examine: pin down the conditions

A raw finding is too compressed to hand to anyone else – "this prompt works," "AI is bad at this." Before the team runs with it, pin down when it works and what judgment it still takes – usually right in the same conversation.

QUESTIONS THAT MAKE A FINDING REUSABLE

1. What task or work was this for – and have you actually tried it here, or seen it elsewhere?
2. What specifically worked or failed?
3. How do you know – did it hold up once, or every time?
4. What did you have to change, check, or decide yourself?
5. Where would you *not* use this?

Note: save these for findings that could change how someone works. And don't force everything into a "best practice" – sometimes the honest answer is "worked once, needs more evidence." That's fine.

4 Spread: make it travel

Mentioning something once isn't spreading it – spreading means someone else can actually pick it up. Three ways: **show it** – a walk-through on a real example, including what was checked or changed; **pair people up** – two people with similar work compare notes and keep what holds up for both; **test it on real work** – someone else tries it on a low-risk task and reports what carried over. Most of this fits meetings you already run. One nudge: don't let the teaching all land on your most advanced user – sharing is part of the work, not a favor.

5 Retain: make it findable

A finding that lives only in a meeting or chat thread is gone in a week. Capture the useful ones where the team already looks – a shared doc, a wiki, a pinned channel – in whatever form is quickest: a short doc, a two-minute video, a screenshot with a caption. Enough to reuse: what the work was, what worked or failed, and the limits – what still needs a human check, where not to use it. Keep it **team memory, not a rulebook**. And when a finding is strong enough to change how the whole team works, don't quietly turn it into a rule: agree it with the team and update the **Team Working Standard**.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Install one recurring learning question in a meeting you already run – and go first, failure included.
- Treat judgment, not speed tips, as the learning most worth spreading.
- Examine before the team runs with anything: where it works, where it doesn't, what it still takes.
- Spread through a person or a task – a demo, a pairing, a low-risk test – never a one-time mention.
- Retain the useful findings, and record the run as the Amplify entry in your **Lead AI Adoption Plan**.

Module 5 · Lead: Capability – the module that turns the standard into durable capability through four ongoing roles. **Next: Lesson 5.5 – Scout – Finding Where AI Can Add Real Value** – the role that looks forward, at what nobody has tried yet.

AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Scout — Finding Where AI Can Add Real Value

Where could AI meaningfully improve our work, and how do I know it's worth adopting?

MODULE 5 · LESSON 5 | LEAD: CAPABILITY | Action lesson · 7–9 min

THE CORE IDEA

Staying ahead means deliberately looking for where AI adds value — and testing it with evidence before it becomes how the team works.

If no one is deliberately looking, the team quietly falls behind while everything still feels fine.

1 The deliberate look

Amplify spreads and keeps what the team has already learned. **Scout** looks the other way — at what nobody has tried yet. Your team may be running well, but AI is moving fast, and so is everyone you compete with — and slow steps, missed tools, and sharper competitors never announce themselves. Scout is the deliberate look: where could AI genuinely move the needle for this team — its capacity, its quality, your product or service, your edge? Not AI for its own sake. If this sounds like innovation or process optimization, it is: the same discipline, pointed at AI, at the scale of your own team. The loop: spot the opportunity, test it, adopt what proves out.

2 Spot the opportunity

Two kinds of signal point to a real opportunity. **Inside the team's work**: a task that takes real time, repeatedly; a recurring quality or rework problem; a bottleneck holding up decisions, delivery, or customers. **Outside it**: a tool the team already uses adds a capability worth a look, or a comparable team or competitor gets results from an approach you haven't tried. A light pulse outward is enough — and you're scouting for your own team, not running pilots across the business. A few times a year — the quarterly review is a natural home — put two questions to the team:

THE TWO TEAM QUESTIONS

1. "Where is repeated work, rework, inconsistency, or a bottleneck costing us — in capacity, quality, decisions, customers, or risk?"
2. "Has anyone tried AI for something the rest of us haven't picked up yet?"

Note: the second is Amplify's learning question pointed forward — hunting for what's next, not catching what's already happening.

A signal on its own isn't a reason to act. Test it against the **two impact questions**: **(1) Would fixing this genuinely help the team** — the time it involves, the people and downstream steps it touches, the effect on capacity, quality, decisions, customers, or risk? **(2) Would the gain be worth the setup and ongoing checking** — counting verification, coordination, and maintenance, not just headline time saved? The test is never "could AI do this?" — it's "would this meaningfully help, and is it worth the effort?" You come out with one qualified candidate.

3 Run the improvement loop

Test the candidate through a simple version of the continuous-improvement cycle teams have trusted for decades – **Plan, Do, Check, Act** – pointed at AI.

Plan – shape the trial

The trial is its own small project: someone owns it, it runs on one real task, and it has an end date. Name up front what a good result looks like – time saved, quality held, what you'd need to see to trust it.

Do & Check – run it and judge it

Judge the result on three things: **value** – did it improve time, capacity, quality, or another outcome that matters? **Quality and judgment** – was it reliable, and what did the person still have to check or decide? **Risk and control** – what could go wrong if this became routine; do the existing checkpoints cover it, or does the Checkpoint Map need updating?

Act – decide

Three calls: **Adopt** – agree the change with the team, update the Team Working Standard, adjust affected checkpoints. **Hold** – useful but not ready; keep it as a reference, revisit later. **Escalate** – it works but needs a decision above your authority; package a decision-ready request, send it through the right channel, and keep the current approved way running until you hear back.

Then it comes around again: adopt feeds the next version of your standard, hold returns when the timing is better, and even "nothing worth pursuing right now" resets the clock to the next scan.

4 The framework is complete

Scout is the fourth and last Lead role. Your **Lead AI Adoption Plan** now holds all four – **Reinforce, Develop, Amplify, Scout** – and from here they run together as one ongoing way of leading adoption, much of it inside meetings and reviews you already run. With the Lead move complete, the whole framework is in place: **Assess, Align, Control, Lead**. What's left isn't another method – it's putting it all into motion.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Run one scan this week and record the Scout entry in your Lead AI Adoption Plan – "nothing worth pursuing right now, and why" is a real result, not a blank.
- Filter every signal through the two impact questions before committing effort.
- Trial before adopting: an owner, one real task, an end date, success named up front.
- Judge trials on value, quality and judgment, and risk and control – then adopt, hold, or escalate.
- Make the scan a habit: a few times a year, ideally in a review you already run.

Module 5 · Lead: Capability – the module that turns the standard into durable capability through four ongoing roles. Download with this lesson: **Handout D – Quarterly Review**. **Next: Module 6** – build your 60-Day Plan with the workbook and the completed example.